Nalini and Murugan’s photographs were passed around. A team of more than a hundred officers, policemen, Cobra commandos and Black Cat commandos stood outside the SIT office building. At the helm of the briefing was Kaarthikeyan. In a booming voice, he addressed his men to boost their morale and wished them luck.

The SIT boss said, ‘First thing, we have to catch them alive. No bullets to be shot as you will be looking for them in crowded places. A bystander’s safety is important. None of you will be in uniform, so mixing with the crowd will be easy. Be very discreet in all your wireless communication. Is that clear?’

‘Clear,’ the men chanted in unison.

‘Best of luck. Let’s go and get them,’ said Kaarthikeyan with conviction.

The tracking team left Malligai in several convoys, then split into three streams and headed in different directions.

A team of the Tamil Nadu Police in plain clothes, CPRF commandos and CBI staff led by Ragothaman kept watch as passengers got off a bus from Madurai that had just arrived at the Chromepet bus terminus. A well-built young man climbed down from its roof and peeped inside through one of the windows as if trying to look for an occupant. His head was shaven. Everyone in the team was immediately alert. Ragothaman’s eyes were fixed on the young man when another bus arrived and stopped right in between him and the bus from Madurai. The terminus was crowded. There was noise and chaos all around. Ragothaman could not see the guy with the shaved head any more. He was lost in the crowd.

A CBI staff member tapped Ragothaman’s back and drew his attention to a man walking away with a young woman. It was the same man. He instantly started following him while the rest of his team gradually formed a loose circle around the couple. All they needed was a signal from Ragothaman to pounce on them. Ragothaman was only a metre away from the couple, but he could not see her face. Suddenly the woman bent down to check her slippers—something seemed to have pricked her feet. The man, too, bent down to check what the problem was. But as she raised her head, it turned out that she was not Nalini. By now Ragothaman was right in front